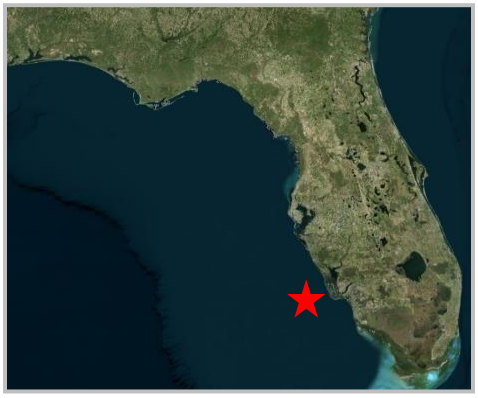
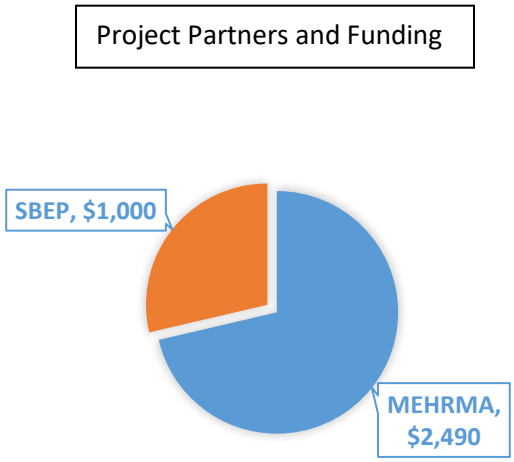
FISH Preserve Coastal Wetlands Restoration and Enhancement Phase III, Cortez, Manatee County, FL

FY 18/19





Project Description



Figure 1: Overgrown exotic vegetation will be cleared to create tidal marsh habitat for fish and wildlife.

Florida Institute for Saltwater Heritage (FISH) Preserve is a 100-acre publically-accessible community conservation property in the historic Village of Cortez, Manatee County. The project area includes tidal creek, mangroves, saltmarsh, and coastal hammock habitats. The purpose of this project is to restore tidal wetland function and enhance habitats for estuarine-dependent species. This project builds upon the success of two completed phases of restoration, continuing the planned control of exotic invasive plants, creation of tidal creeks, and planting of intertidal marsh with beneficial native grasses. This project involved engineering and design plan updates during 2018 and 2019, as well as development of specifications for construction. The project is fully shovel-ready for construction of Phase III during fiscal year 2019/2020. Additional project funding in FY18/19 was contributed by Sarasota Bay Estuary Program (SBEP), the project partner and permittee, through in-kind project management services. $284,000 in leveraged funds from the first two phases of the project were provided by SBEP, Southwest Florida Water Management District, and Southeast Aquatic Resources Partnership.

Benefits

- Provide nursery and foraging habitat for a variety of wildlife including juvenile fish, invertebrates, oysters, wading birds, and shorebirds.

FWC Strategic Plan Elements Supported

Theme 1, Goal 1. Ensure the sustainability of Florida's fish and wildlife populations.

Strategy:

- Manage non-listed species to prevent them from meeting Florida's listing criteria for endangered and threatened species.

Theme 1, Goal 2. Ensure that sufficient habitat exists to support healthy populations of all native species of fish and wildlife.

Strategy:

- Manage habitats to sustain healthy and diverse fish and wildlife populations.

Theme 2, Goal 1. Provide residents and visitors with quality fishing, hunting, boating, and wildlife viewing opportunities that meet their needs and expectations while providing for the sustainability of the natural resources involved.

Strategy:

- Develop and maintain widely available, diverse, and accessible fishing, hunting, boating, and wildlife-viewing opportunities that meet the needs and expectations of residents and visitors, provide for the sustainability of those resources, and emphasize partnerships with both public and private landowners.

Theme 3, Goal 4. Encourage communities to conserve lands and waters critical to sustaining healthy and diverse populations of fish and wildlife.

Strategies:

- Provide communities with the assistance necessary to help them obtain the social and economic benefits of local conservation lands.

Acreage to be restored by habitat type (footprint)

Total- 0.71 acres estuarine habitat:

- Tidal creek habitat- 0.18 acre
- Saltmarsh habitat- 0.53 acre

Acreage affected by restoration activities: 7.10 acres (includes acreage listed above and 6.39 acres of adjacent estuarine wetland)



Figure 2: Saltmarsh and open water habitat created during prior phases of FISH Preserve restoration by project partners.



Figure 3: Tidal creek habitat created during prior phases of FISH Preserve restoration by project partners.